TMC to bring resolution against ECI

SAUGAR SENGUPTA ■ Kolkata

The special session of the Bengal Assembly on Monday is all set to witness a turbulent meeting with the Trinamool Congress Government proposing to bring a resolution against the Election Commission of India (ECI), which conducted Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of the electoral rolls and alleged harassment of Bengali-speaking migrant workers in BJP-ruled States.

The special session will continue till Friday. To counter the TMC's move, the BJP is likely to raise the issue of corruption in the school teachers' recruitment that led the State School Service Commission to publish the names of 1806 "tainted" candidates who had manipulated the selection process to secure teachers' jobs. The Staff Selection Commission (SSC) was forced to publish the names on Saturday evening following a strong order of the Supreme Court.

Though there was confusion among some legislators, even belonging to the ruling outfit, about whether a move taken by the Election Commission of India could be taken up for condemnation — particularly in relation to its implementation in Bihar — the top legislative leadership of the party said there were proposals to bring a resolution against SIR and the way it was being implemented in the neighbouring State.

"The session will be held on September 1, 2 and 4 since September 3 is a State holiday. A motion is likely to be moved on the atrocities faced by migrant workers from West Bengal," said Speaker Biman Banerjee.

State Parliamentary Affairs Minister Sobhandeb Chattopadhyay said that "There are proposals to raise the two most important issues for which the session has been summoned." Another MLA said the way the migrant workers from Bengal had been harassed and insulted in the BJP-ruled States with a "specific intention of denigrating the State and its culture needs condemnation, already our leader and Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee has declared a year-long agitation to protect the honour of our mother tongue and culture."

"Are we to be called Bangladeshis because we speak the Bengali language? They are branding us Bangladeshis. The creation of Bangladesh is not our fault. Ironically the two states of Bengal and Punjab that fought the most and led the freedom struggle from the front were partitioned and today we are forced to face the humiliation. This must be condemned," the Chief Minister earlier said, alleging how many detainees in Haryana and some other states were secretly deported to Bangladesh by the Border Security Force.

TMC Chief Whip Nirmal Ghosh, on the other hand, said his party will register its protests related to both migrant workers and SIR. "It is clear that an SIR is being planned in Bengal to delete millions of names, something we witnessed in Bihar," Ghosh said. "We have been directed by the Chief Minister to thwart this attempt at any cost. We will not tolerate the deletion of even a single name in the name of SIR. After condemning it inside the Assembly we will resist it on streets," he added.

BJP Chief Whip Shankar Ghosh, on the other hand, said that his party would hold a Legislature Party meeting and would discuss its strategy.

"But definitely we are going to raise the issue of corruption in school recruitment. The list that has been published by the SSC at the direction of the Supreme Court makes it clear how the relatives and acquaintances of the TMC MLAs, netas and councilors secured their jobs through backdoor by manipulating the selection process."

SDM orders vacation of commercial buildings in Katra's vulnerable zones

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

After witnessing a massive landslide near Ardhkuwari in which 34 pilgrims lost their lives and over 20 others received injuries on August 26, the Sub Division Magistrate, Katra, has now ordered the immediate vacation of commercial establishments, including hotels, in the vulnerable zones for the safety of the pilgrims.

Meanwhile, the pilgrimage to the Mata Vaishno Devi shrine atop the Trikuta hills remained suspended for the sixth consecutive day on Sunday due to inclement weather.

In an order, Katra Sub-Division Magistrate (SDM) Piyush Dhotra ordered the vacation of all commercial establishments, including hotels and dharamshalas, from Balini bridge to Darshani Deodi and from Balini bridge to Asia Chowk in the vulnerable zones for the safety and security of the pilgrims.

"Heavy rains and inclement weather conditions have resulted in massive landslides in the Katra sub-division in recent days, especially near Balini bridge and near Shan temple at Kadmal, besides the sinking of roads at a few spots, making some places vulnerable to future landslides and damage.

"This has the potential to endanger human lives (and) keeping in view the number of pilgrims visiting Katra town for Shri Mata Vaishno Devi Yatra it is imperative to assess the safety of the structures of the commercial establishments located in Katra for the overall safety and security of the pilgrims," the order read.

In view of the recent incidents, the SDM said all the commercial establishments located on the hill from Asia Chowk to Balini bridge and from Balini bridge to Darshani Deodi have become vulnerable and their continued operation poses a risk to public safety and security in view of the prevailing situation.

"In exercise of the powers conferred under Section 163 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, I hereby order the vacation of all commercial establishments located on the stretch from Asia Chowk to Balini bridge and from Balini bridge to Darshani Deodi with immediate effect, till these establishments obtain a safety certificate from the executive engineer, Public Works Department (Roads and Buildings), Katra," the SDM said.

He said any violation of the order shall invite strict punitive action under section 223 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita.

India Post suspends all mail services to US

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India Post has suspended all categories of mail operations destined to the US in the absence of clarity over new rules issued by the US Customs Department, an official statement said on Sunday.

Earlier, the country's postal department had temporarily suspended postal services for gifts valued above $100 due to the new custom rules issued by the US Government.

"In continuation of the Public Notice dated August 22, 2025, the Department of Posts has reviewed the suspension of booking of mail to the United States of America. In view of the ongoing inability of carriers to transport US-bound mail and in the absence of defined regulatory mechanisms, it has been decided to completely suspend the booking of all categories of mail, including letters, documents, and gift items valued up to $100, destined for the USA," the statement said.

The Department of Posts said that it is closely monitoring the situation and making every effort to restore services at the earliest. "Customers who have already booked items that could not be dispatched may claim a refund of postage," the statement said.

On August 23, the department had said the postal services from India to the US had been temporarily suspended due to denial of carrying shipments by US-bound air carriers due to the lack of clarity in new norms issued by the US Customs Department.

Under an executive order issued by the US administration on July 30, 2025, goods valued above $100 are subject to customs duties in the US with effect from August 29 onwards.

As per the Executive Order, transport carriers delivering shipments through the international postal network, or other "qualified parties" approved by the US Customs and Border Protection (CBP), are required to collect and remit duties on postal shipments.

While CBP had issued certain guidelines on August 15, several critical processes relating to the designation of "qualified parties" and mechanisms for duty collection and remittance remain undefined.

CM Abdullah visits Ramban, Udhampur districts to assess devastation caused by recent cloudbursts

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

Ahead of the arrival of Union Home Minister Amit Shah in Jammu, Chief Minister Omar Abdullah on Sunday carried out an extensive tour of Ramban and Udhampur districts to assess the widespread devastation caused by recent cloudbursts, flash floods, landslides, and mudslides, which have severely disrupted life and damaged the Jammu–Srinagar National Highway (NH-44).

The traffic on NH-44 remained disrupted for the sixth consecutive day amid ongoing restoration work.

Shah is scheduled to arrive in Jammu late Sunday evening on a two-day tour and is expected to conduct an aerial survey of the flood-hit areas before chairing a high-level meeting at the Raj Bhavan on Monday.

Chief Minister Omar Abdullah is expected to submit a detailed report to the Union Home Minister during the meeting at the Raj Bhavan.

Briefing media persons during his inspection visit, Omar Abdullah said, "The home minister is solely coming here to assess the situation in the aftermath of the heavy rains and flash floods and look at our requirement from the Centre (to cope with the crisis). He has no other purpose, and he is not coming for security or development review," Abdullah said.

Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah reviews the road condition and restoration works following heavy rainfall in Ramban PTI

Earlier, Omar Abdullah visited Maroge in Ramban, where he inspected the severely damaged stretch of NH-44 and directed the National Highways Authority of India (NHAI), BEACON and other executing agencies to restore this vital road link on a war footing.

Reviewing relief and rehabilitation efforts in Rajgarh, which was hit by a devastating cloudburst, the Chief Minister assured the affected families that adequate assistance will be provided under the State Disaster Relief Fund (SDRF)..

He directed officials to ensure timely support for those in distress, while the Deputy Commissioner Ramban, Mohammad Alyas Khan, informed CM that immediate financial aid from the District Red Cross Fund has already been disbursed.

During his visit, Omar Abdullah also took stock of the availability of essential commodities, healthcare facilities, and critical services across the district.

Later, the Chief Minister visited the damaged portions of NH-44 at Bali Nallah and Thard in Udhampur district. He inspected the ongoing restoration works and instructed executing agencies to deploy additional men and machinery for speedy clearance of debris and repair of the highway.

Stressing that restoration of road connectivity is the Government's top priority, Omar Abdullah asked the district administration to ensure that all possible measures are adopted to reopen the road at the earliest.

He emphasized that at least one tube of the highway must be opened urgently to facilitate the transportation of essential supplies to Kashmir and ease the hardships of the people.

During his interaction with the local residents at Bali Nallah and Thard, Omar Abdullah listened to their grievances and assured them of full government support. He directed the administration to immediately provide ration, clean drinking water, restore power supply, set-up temporary shelters and provide other assistance to families whose houses have been damaged. He stressed that the first priority is the safe relocation of affected families from vulnerable areas, followed by a comprehensive rehabilitation programme once connectivity is restored.

Union Home Minister Amit Shah during the inauguration of urban health centers in Ahmedabad district PTI

Amit Shah inaugurates urban health centre

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

Union Home Minister Amit Shah participated in a tree plantation drive and also inaugurated an urban health centre here on Sunday.

Shah and Gujarat Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel led the tree plantation drive under the "Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam" initiative in Ahmedabad's Ghatlodia ward.

The campaign encourages people to plant a tree in the name of their mother. The programme was organised at Ayushman Van by the Ahmedabad Municipal Corporation (AMC).

In a separate event, Shah inaugurated an urban health centre in Gota ward of Ahmedabad built at a cost of Rs 3.84 crore.

The centre will make available services like PMJAY card under Ayushman Bharat, Abha Card, Pradhan Mantri Matru Vandana Yojana, Janani Suraksha Yojana along with all other health-related services, a release said.

In addition, it will also facilitate diagnosis, treatment and referral services for pregnant women, lactating mothers and women's diseases by gynaecologists.

The examination, diagnosis, treatment and referral services for newborns and children by pediatricians, and services related to vaccination of pregnant women and children will also be available, the release said.

Rajasthan to introduce stringent version of anti-conversion bill

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Jaipur

The Rajasthan Government will introduce a more stringent version of a bill to curb religious conversions carried out through coercion, misrepresentation or fraudulent means in the Assembly session that starts from Monday.

The proposed legislation includes tough penalties for offenders, with imprisonment ranging from seven to fourteen years and a minimum fine of ₹5 lakh in general cases. For cases of mass conversion, the bill proposes imprisonment from 20 years to life and a minimum fine of ₹25 lakh.

State Law and Legal Affairs Minister Jogaram Patel said that Rajasthan currently has no specific law to address illegal conversions. The earlier version of the bill, introduced in the previous session, will now be withdrawn and replaced with a revised draft containing stricter provisions.

The new draft of the Rajasthan Prohibition of Unlawful Religious Conversion Bill, 2025, was approved during a meeting of the state Cabinet chaired by Chief Minister Bhajanlal Sharma on Sunday.

The minister said that the bill prohibits any person or organisation from inducing religious conversion through deception, force, undue influence or fraudulent methods.

It also states that any marriage solemnised solely for the purpose of religious conversion will be declared null and void. All offences under the proposed law will be cognisable and non-bailable.

Patel clarified that returning to one's ancestral religion will not be treated as conversion under the bill.

In the proposed legislation, for cases involving minors, women, persons with disabilities or individuals from SC/ST communities, the punishment will range from ten to twenty years and a minimum fine of ₹10 lakh.

Accepting foreign or unauthorised funding for the purpose of conversion will attract imprisonment of ten to twenty years and a fine of at least Rs 20 lakh. In offences involving coercion, marriage fraud, human trafficking or vulnerable victims, the punishment will be twenty years to life imprisonment and a fine of no less than Rs 30 lakh, he said.

Repeat offenders may be sentenced to life imprisonment and fined not less than ₹50 lakh. Institutions involved in unlawful conversion may have their registration cancelled and state grants withdrawn. Properties used for unlawful conversion may be confiscated or demolished after investigation.

BJP governments in many states, including Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Madhya Pradesh and Gujarat, have enacted laws to check illegal religious conversion.

Another important decision in the cabinet meeting on Sunday was about the implementation of the PM Surya Ghar Electricity Scheme aimed at providing 150 units of free electricity per month to domestic consumers registered under the Chief Minister Free Electricity Scheme through solar power.

Punjab police bust BKI-backed terror module, arrest 2 operatives

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Chandigarh

The Punjab Police on Sunday said it has busted a Babbar Khalsa International (BKI)-backed terror module and thwarted major disruptive activities in the state with the arrest of its two operatives.

The module was busted by the Counter Intelligence (CI) teams from Pathankot and Ludhiana, as well as the State Special Operations Cell (SSOC) in Amritsar.

Director General of Police (DGP) Gaurav Yadav said the arrested have been identified as Sarwan Kumar, a resident of Malhian village in Gurdaspur and Balwinder Singh, a resident of Jakkriya in Gurdaspur.

During a search, police teams recovered a hand grenade and a pistol along with three live cartridges from their possession.

The development came in less than a week after CI Pathankot averted a target killing by busting a module of the same network with the four members, including two juveniles and recovered two pistols from their possession. Preliminary investigations revealed that the accused were working on the directions of their foreign-based handlers, who are allegedly backed by the BKI. They were introduced to these handlers by an intermediary, Yadav said.

The DGP confirmed that a case has been registered under relevant sections of the law, and efforts are ongoing to trace and apprehend other members associated with this network.

Sharing further details, Assistant Inspector General, CI Pathankot, Sukhminder Singh Mann said the accused were tasked to conduct a recce of various security establishments. To execute the assignment, they were provided with explosives and funds.

They were allegedly communicating with their handlers using encrypted apps and virtual phone numbers, Mann mentioned. The AIG noted that further investigations are being conducted to unearth the complete BKI-backed network and investigate previous crimes committed by the arrested individuals.

In a separate operation, the Anti-Gangster Task Force (AGTF) of the Punjab Police arrested two suspected associates of the Prabh Dassuwal-Gopi Ganshampur gang for their alleged involvement in a recent shooting incident at a salon in Patti, Tarn Taran.

The arrested have been identified as Gurpreet Singh alias Gandhi, a resident of Khadoor Sahib in Tarn Taran, and Jaskaran alias Karan, a resident of Phailoke village in Tarn Taran. Police also recovered three country-made .30 bore pistols from their possession, according to Yadav.

On August 24, three individuals on motorcycles fired shots at a salon whose owner had been receiving extortion calls from unknown numbers for a few months.

Yadav stated that the investigation revealed both accused were in touch with foreign-based gangster Prabh Dassuwal from the Gopi Ghanshampuria gang and executed the shooting on his orders to extort money.

Radha Ashtami celebrated with fervour in Mathura temple

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mathura (UP)

Thousands of devotees thronged the Shri Radharani Temple at Barsana in Mathura to celebrate Radha Ashtami and participate in the Abhishek Mahotsav on Sunday.

For the first time, live streaming of the celebration was enabled by the district administration, in collaboration with the temple management. Heavy security arrangements were also made.

As the Abhishek (consecration) of the diety began on Sunday morning, the entire surroundings reverberated with the chanting of 'Radharani Ki Jai'. The devotees also started dancing, chanting 'Radhey Radhey'.

Women sang Mangalgeet, saints chanted Vedic hymns, and children danced in the rain, turning the streets of Barsana into a living canvas of devotion and joy.

When the heavens opened, elderly devotees called it a divine sign. "This is not an ordinary rain, it is the divine anointment of Radharani's birth," they said. A day before, the Goswami community of Nandgaon visited the Laadli Ji temple and distributed sweets.

The prakatotsav was celebrated at 4 am in the Radharani temple at Rawal village, located near Mahavan in Mathura, believed to be the birthplace of Radharani, the beloved daughter of Vrishbhanu and Kirtidevi.

According to tradition, she was born on the eighth day of Shukla Paksha in the Bhadrapad month during the Dwapar era.

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Russia, China oppose sanctions against BRICS...

Prime Minister Narendra Modi is due to meet Putin on the sidelines of the SCO summit being held here from Sunday to Monday.

In the written interview with Xinhua, Putin said Russia and China support reforming the International Monetary Fund and the World Bank.

He added that the two sides share the view that a new financial system must be built on the principles of "openness and true equity", which can provide equal and non-discriminatory access to its tools for all countries and reflect the real standing of member states in the global economy.

"We seek progress for the benefit of all humanity. I am confident that Russia and China will continue to work together towards this noble goal, aligning our efforts to ensure the prosperity of our great nations," he said.

Besides attending the summit and holding talks with Chinese President Xi Jinping, Putin will also attend China's V-Day parade to commemorate the 80th anniversary of its victory against Japan in WWII.

He hoped that the SCO Tianjin Summit will inject powerful new momentum into the 10-member organisation and strengthen its capacity to respond to contemporary challenges and threats, and consolidate solidarity across the shared Eurasian space.

"All this will help shape a fairer multipolar world order," he said.

The SCO's appeal lies in its simple but powerful principles: a firm commitment to its founding philosophy, openness to equal cooperation, not targeting third parties, and respect for the national characteristics and uniqueness of each nation, he said.

"Drawing on these values, the SCO contributes to shaping a fairer, multipolar world order, grounded in international law, with the central coordinating role of the United Nations," he said. "I am confident that, through our joint efforts, we will give the SCO new momentum, modernising it to meet the demands of the time," he said.